

“... sometimes I **think I shall not be able to endure** it. ... never since I have **worked in the mill** have I been **so very tired** ...”

MARY PAUL, LOWELL MILL GIRL, MASSACHUSETTS, 1845

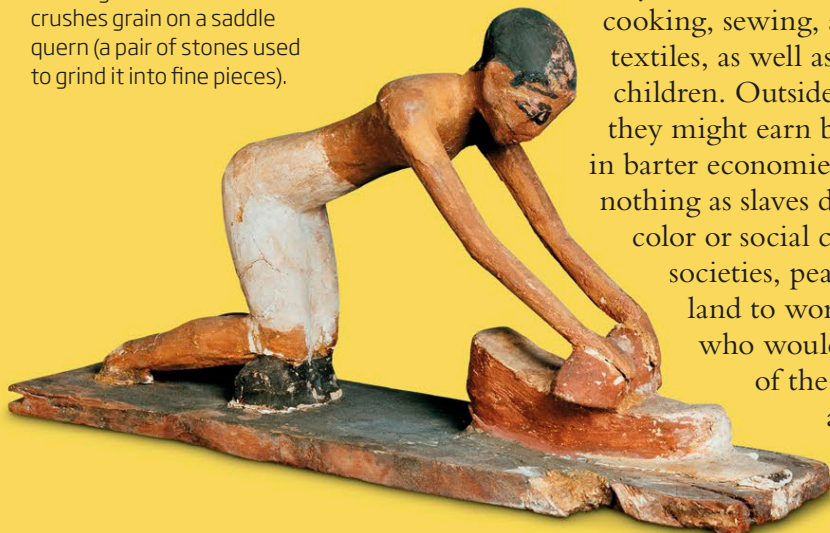
EXPERIENCES OF WORK

Nine to five

The idea that women in the workforce should earn a salary is a relatively recent one. Women's work was often unpaid, poorly paid, or overlooked altogether. In the 21st century, women are still battling gender inequality in pay and access to various types of jobs.

▼ The daily grind

This figurine of a woman from Egypt's Sixth Dynasty (2325–2175 BCE) shows her working in the home. She crushes grain on a saddle quern (a pair of stones used to grind it into fine pieces).



RESTRICTED ACCESS TO EDUCATION

as well as religious and cultural conventions has limited women's working lives. However, that does not mean that women have not worked; their contribution has always played a vital role in how society functions even if that has not always been recognized. Historically, many women worked in the home: cooking, sewing, and making textiles, as well as caring for their children. Outside of the home, they might earn by trading goods in barter economies, or work for nothing as slaves due to their skin color or social class. In feudal societies, peasants were given land to work by their lord, who would retain part of the crop's yield and some of the profit from its

sale. While women worked the land, they were legally their husbands' property, and therefore did not receive an individual benefit for their own work. Contrastingly, in modern economies, the most common form of arrangement is wage work, in which men and women sell their labor in exchange for a salary.

Rural and urban

During the medieval and early modern periods, women in Europe had varying roles and opportunities. Women living in rural communities assisted their fathers and husbands in tending livestock, and participated in cottage industries like baking and weaving, while those in urban environments assisted male

family members in trades and crafts, such as metalwork, producing leather goods and textiles, and running shops and inns. From the 1300s, many women made a living from brewing beer. These “alewives,” some of whom were single or widowed, brewed alcohol over large cauldrons and often wore

“Do not **choose your wife** at a **dance**, but **on the field among the harvesters**.”

CZECH PROVERB